

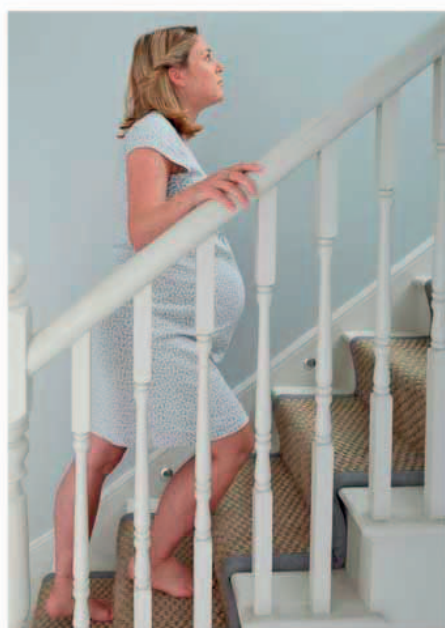
Q What are the best birthing positions to adopt during first stage labor?

A combination of active and restful positions help you to get through first stage labor. Active positions are thought to encourage the progression of labor, and restful, supported positions allow you to have vital respite between contractions.

Standing upright in labor encourages your baby to move down, deep into your pelvis, and to press against your cervix. This has the effect of sending messages to your brain to release more of the hormone oxytocin, which stimulates further contractions. These become more frequent, longer, and more effective than in other birthing positions, which makes labor shorter than if you were lying down. Walking

around also helps your baby to move lower into your pelvis, so labor progresses more quickly. Studies show that staying active in the first stage makes you less likely to ask for pain relief or to need a C-section, and your baby is less likely to become distressed. However, lying down and sitting positions allow you to recover from contractions, but don't stay still for too long since it will slow down your labor.

Follow your **instincts** and decide yourself how you want to **move, sit, or stand** during first stage labor.



Walking up and down stairs If you have stairs near you, use them to keep active. Remember to hold on to the bannister for support.



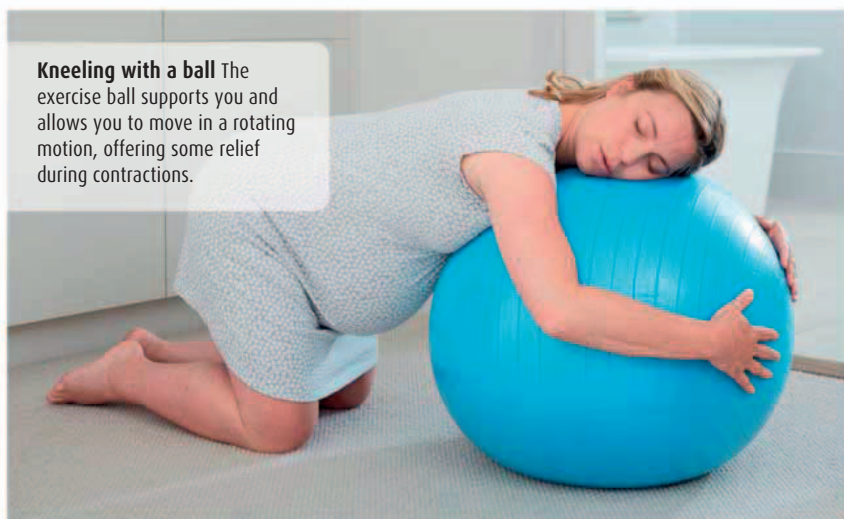
Standing, leaning on a tall chair or stool Use a chair to support your body weight. Place a cushion under your arms for extra comfort.



Standing, leaning on bed Ease back pain by adopting this pose. This particularly helps when your baby is lying with her back against your spine.



Standing, leaning on ball This position allows you to continue to stand, even if you're getting tired, since the ball supports the bulk of your body weight.



Kneeling with a ball The exercise ball supports you and allows you to move in a rotating motion, offering some relief during contractions.